

Tech Tip: How to Block Location Tracking on your Phone

Smartphones have become valuable tools for helping to organize our lives. However, the devices can also capture personal data and location information that users might want to keep private.

Here are some tips, suggested by the Associated Press (AP), to help smartphone users limit the collection of private data on personal devices.

How does a smartphone track your location?

All a user has to do is open a phone's map tool to search for a restaurant or other business to activate data tracking. Similarly, someone choosing to look up the price of a product online can unknowingly permit the smartphone to track the user's location and share data with others.

Darren Guccione is the chief executive of U.S.-based internet security company Keeper Security. He told the AP that many apps, "from fitness tracking to navigation," can record data signals that show a user's movements, both physical and digital.

Guccione's advice to users is to "turn on location tracking only when necessary, such as during navigation, emergencies or sharing updates with trusted contacts..." He adds that after this kind of necessary tracking is complete, users should immediately turn off location tracking.

Identify your app permissions

One step to limit smartphone tracking is to identify and change app permission settings. To do this, iPhone users can first go to the device's Privacy & Security settings. Then go to Location Services to check settings for individual apps.

Internet security experts say it is not a good idea to let apps always use your location in the background. Instead, get the app to either ask first before using your location, or use it only when the app is open. A user can also choose the setting that never lets an app track location.

The process works a little differently for Android phones because manufacturers have different versions. In general, Android users should go to settings. Then go to Location to turn the setting on or off for all apps.

Ad trackers

To avoid being tracked by advertising systems, privacy experts suggest that users block advertising identifiers on Android or Apple devices. This can stop third parties from tracking ads to target users.

To do this, iPhone users can go to the Privacy setting, then find Apple Advertising. Then turn off Personalized Ads. On newer Android phones, users should go to the Privacy setting, then to Ads, and choose Delete Advertising ID.

Check your Google account

Along with app permissions for your device, security experts say it is a good idea to look closely at your Google account to make sure it is not tracking you.

To find this out, go to myaccount.google.com and find Data & Privacy. Users can find Location History controls there. Under recent changes, the history will be removed after three months although users can change that setting as well.

How to use web browsers

Popular web browsers for smartphones – like Safari or Chrome – could also give away location information. Try using one that does not store your data. Such browsers include DuckDuckGo, Firefox Focus or Ecosia.

If a privacy-protected browser needs to identify your location through an IP address, it will ask first before doing so. These kinds of browsers will also let users easily remove internet cookies and other web browsing data.

Find my device

Phones or tablets can also be tracked with Apple's Find My or Google's Find My Device services designed to recover lost devices. Users can turn this tool off if they think someone was able to take control of their Apple or Google account and is using it for tracking.

Block the signal

Some cybersecurity websites advise using a smartphone's Airplane Mode to block tracking operations. But some experts say this does not always turn off all tracking signals. Users should not depend on this setting alone to block data collection.

A better tool in many situations would be a signal-blocking Faraday bag. These block all wireless signals to the smartphone. Experts suggest testing the bag to make sure data is actually being blocked. While such bags can be helpful, devices kept inside the containers cannot be used.

I'm Bryan Lynn.

The Associated Press reported this story. Bryan Lynn adapted the report for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

location - n. สถานที่ที่คนไปหรือบางสิ่งเกิดขึ้น

track - v. ติดตามการเคลื่อนไหวของบางสิ่ง

navigation - n. วิธีการหาทิศทางที่ถูกต้องในการเดินทางโดยใช้แผนที่หรืออุปกรณ์อื่น ๆ

digital - adj. ข้อมูลใด ๆ ที่ถูกแปลงจากรูปแบบไฟฟ้าหรือกายภาพไปเป็นรูปแบบที่คอมพิวเตอร์ใช้

cookie - n. ไฟล์ข้อมูลขนาดเล็กที่ถูกจัดเก็บไว้ในคอมพิวเตอร์ของผู้ใช้อินเทอร์เน็ตขณะที่พวกเขาเรียกดูเว็บไซต์ต่าง ๆ

tablet - n. คอมพิวเตอร์ขนาดเล็กที่ใช้หน้าจอสัมผัส

bag - n. ภาชนะที่ทำจากกระดาษ พลาสติก เป็นต้น ซึ่งใช้สำหรับบรรจุสิ่งของ

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. According to the second paragraph, what is a dual characteristic of smartphones?

They are expensive but essential communication tools.

They are valuable tools but can also capture private data.

They are primarily for entertainment but also for work.

They are difficult to use but offer advanced features.

2. What is the main purpose of the tips provided in the article, as stated in paragraph 3?

To encourage users to share more personal data.

To help users customize their smartphone interfaces.

To limit the collection of private data on personal devices.

To promote new smartphone security apps.

3. According to paragraph 5, which action can *unknowingly* lead to a smartphone tracking a user's location?

Sending a text message to a friend.

Making a phone call to a business.

Looking up the price of a product online.

Taking a photo with the phone's camera.

4. What is Darren Guccione's professional role and company, as mentioned in paragraph 6?

A journalist for the Associated Press.

The chief executive of Keeper Security.

A professor of digital privacy at a university.

A developer of navigation apps.

5. What specific advice does Darren Guccione give regarding location tracking in paragraph 7?

Always keep location tracking on for safety.

Turn it on only when necessary and turn it off immediately after.

Share location updates with all contacts regularly.

Only use location tracking during navigation, never for emergencies.

6. For iPhone users, what is the initial step to check app location settings, according to paragraph 9?

Go to the App Store and download a privacy app.

Go to the device's Privacy & Security settings.

Restart the phone and check notifications.

Update the iOS operating system to the latest version.

7. Which of the following is **not recommended by internet security experts for app location usage, according to paragraph 10?**

Allowing apps to ask first before using your location.

Using location only when the app is open.

Choosing the setting that never lets an app track location.

Allowing apps to always use your location in the background.

8. How do Android users generally manage location settings for all apps, as described in paragraph 11?

By downloading a third-party location manager app.

By going to settings, then Location to turn it on or off.

By contacting their phone manufacturer for specific instructions.

By adjusting settings within each individual app.

9. According to privacy experts in paragraph 13, what is the purpose of blocking advertising identifiers?

To improve smartphone battery life.

To prevent third parties from tracking ads to target users.

To speed up internet browsing.

To increase the number of personalized ads received.

10. What specific action should iPhone users take to turn off personalized ads, according to paragraph 14?

Go to Safari settings and clear website data.

Go to Privacy, then Apple Advertising, then turn off Personalized Ads.

Delete the advertising ID from the device's main settings.

Disable location services for all apps.

11. Besides app permissions, what other account should users check for tracking, according to security experts in paragraph 16?

Their social media accounts.

Their email provider account.

Their Google account.

Their banking application accounts.

12. Where can users find Location History controls for their Google account, as stated in paragraph 17?

Within the Google Maps application settings.

On their smartphone's general privacy settings.

At myaccount.google.com under Data & Privacy.

By contacting Google customer support.

13. Which of the following is suggested as a privacy-focused web browser in paragraph 19?

Safari

Chrome

Microsoft Edge

DuckDuckGo

14. What is a characteristic of privacy-protected browsers regarding location identification, according to paragraph 20?

They automatically block all location access.

They will ask for permission before identifying location via IP address.

They never use IP addresses for any purpose.

They always identify your location without asking.

15. Why might a user choose to turn off 'Find My' or 'Find My Device' services, according to paragraph 22?

To save battery life on their smartphone.

To prevent accidental device recovery.

If they suspect their account has been compromised and used for tracking.

Because these services are outdated and no longer useful.